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THE HINDU

Tracing the origin of Madurai's jigarthanda, a summer favourite across the State **P2**

HOW RATHNA KUMAR EXPLORES LOVE IN 29 **P4**



A ticket to power

From *Thamizhan* to *Jana Nayagan*: This is how Tamil cinema laid the groundwork for TVK chief Vijay's historical political debut

ROUTE TO SUCCESS

Thalaivaa (2013)

Kaththi (2014)

Mersal (2017)

Sarkar (2018)



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At Tirupattur in Sivaganga district, the counting of votes for the Assembly elections played out like a Vijay film.

During the final round of counting, election officials declared that the candidate belonging to the Tamilaga Vettri Kazhagam (TVK) won by a single vote over his rival.

Now, take that in: *a single vote*.

This is pretty much a scene from Vijay's own 2018 film, *Sarkar*. For those not clued into Tamil cinema, this film, directed by AR Murugadoss, revolves around a wealthy corporate professional who visits Chennai for a single day to cast his vote... only to find that his vote has been compromised. The peeved CEO – who, interestingly, is named Sundar Ramaswamy, which made fans draw parallels to Google's Sundar Pichai – decides to stay back to fight his case, contest elections and assume political power in a storyline that can happen only in reel life.

Or so we thought, till the counting day of the Tamil Nadu Assembly elections 2026, which resulted in a stunning debut for the actor-turned-politician as

TVK emerged the single largest party with 108 seats. This unexpected result for a party, founded just over two years ago, is not just a reflection of the star's charisma but also his decision to quit a thriving film career, one that had him earning more than ₹200 crores per project. Much like popular personalities and former Chief Ministers MG Ramachandran and J Jayalalithaa, who were both film stars turned politicians, 51-year-old Vijay too banked heavily on the large fan base that he has been carefully building over three decades.

This victory for the star might not just be the result of stirring political speeches and an electoral manifesto that promises many financial benefits to the people. It is also the result of message-laced commercial cinema that projected Vijay as the saviour of the masses, and which was probably amplified by the several political hurdles and red tape he faced at the time of release of these films.

"He would have been just another actor, but every project landed in some controversy," says film producer G Dhananjayan, "However, from *Thalaivaa* till the recent *Jana Nayagan*, his work has been pulled by political forces – so much that he decided to get into public life himself. I would say that politicians have driven him to politics."

CONTINUED ON
» **PAGE 3**

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The Chennai ORR: A Revolution in Urban Living

In Chennai, the city's growth has always been felt as much in everyday life as on a map, in the homes people choose, the time they spend on the road, and the rhythms that shape their days. Its corridors have long set this pace. OMR brought work closer to home and turned once-distant stretches into bustling, self-contained neighbourhoods. ECR, in contrast, offered a more unhurried way of living, where open skies, coastal drives, and slower weekends became part of the lifestyle itself.

Now, the Chennai Outer Ring Road (ORR) is beginning to shape a new kind of urban experience. Not defined by a single way of life, but by the freedom to combine many. Here, distance feels less restrictive, access more intuitive, and the lines between living, working, and unwinding begin to blur. In that shift, ORR is doing more than supporting the city's expansion, it is redefining what it means to live well in a growing Chennai.

The kind of lifestyle shift and prosperity that Outer Ring Roads can bring has already been demonstrated in neighbouring cities such as Hyderabad and Bengaluru. Hyderabad's Outer Ring Road (ORR) offers a strong example of how strategic infrastructure can drive economic and lifestyle transformation at scale. Similarly, Bengaluru's ORR has been instrumental in powering the city's robust ecosystem of businesses, talent, and urban development.

Together, these corridors highlight how strong connectivity can accelerate economic activity, drive real estate growth, and enable the development of self-sustaining urban ecosystems, offering a clear direction for Chennai's ORR as it continues to evolve.

Days That Flow, Not Fracture

One of the most noticeable lifestyle shifts along the ORR is in how the day unfolds. In many parts of Chennai, routines are fragmented by long commutes and unpredictable traffic, but here, movement is becoming more seamless. The Chennai Outer Ring Road (ORR) significantly enhances travel efficiency



by enabling faster, seamless movement across the city. By connecting key national highways and major junctions, it allows both freight and passenger



traffic to bypass congested urban cores, reducing reliance on inner-city roads. As a result, cross-city travel times are reduced by approximately 30 to 60 minutes, depending on traffic conditions, making daily commutes and logistics more predictable and time-efficient.

"The Chennai Outer Ring Road has been one of the most impactful infrastructure upgrades in recent years, significantly improving connectivity between key corridors like GST Road, NH48, and OMR. Travel time reduction and better logistics access have made it a strong alternative to saturated city zones," notes Mr P Johnson, Vice President – Chennai & Coimbatore, JLL. This reliability reshapes everyday life. Mornings begin with less urgency, and evenings are no longer defined by fatigue. Instead, there is a smoother flow to the day, one that leaves room for both productivity and pause.

The City, Without the Weight of It

The ORR is also transforming how residents perceive distance and access. Neighbourhoods such as Tambaram, Vandalur, Thirumudivakkam, and Poonamallee are no longer seen as distant edges, while established areas like Ambattur and Mogappair feel more integrated into the city's rhythm. This creates a version of Chennai that feels expansive yet accessible. Residents here get to engage with different parts of the city without being overwhelmed by its density. The experience of "going into the city" becomes less of an effort and more of a natural extension of the day, subtly but significantly improving how urban life is lived.

Space as Everyday Comfort, Not Occasional Luxury

Space has become one of the most defining aspects of the ORR lifestyle. In contrast to denser urban pockets, this corridor offers wider roads, larger developments, and layouts that prioritise openness. The result is an environment that feels less compressed and more breathable. Homes here are

designed to accommodate evolving needs, serving as workspaces, social zones, and personal retreats without feeling restrictive. Natural light, ventilation, and spatial fluidity become part of everyday living rather than aspirational features. In this context, space is not simply about size; it is about how comfortably life can unfold within it, making it a foundational element of the lifestyle that ORR enables.

Close to Opportunity, Yet Removed from Its Intensity

Another defining feature of the ORR is its ability to balance proximity to work with a sense of detachment from its pressures. With employment hubs across Sriperumbudur, Oragadam, and Porur, residents remain closely connected to opportunity. Yet, these hubs do not dominate the surrounding environment in the way central business districts often do. This allows for a more sustainable rhythm of living. Work is accessible, but home retains its calm. Evenings feel unhurried, and weekends do not



demand an escape from the city. Instead, life feels inherently more balanced, where professional and personal spheres coexist without constant overlap.

A Social Fabric That Evolves With You

Lifestyle is shaped as much by community as by infrastructure, and along the ORR, this social fabric is steadily taking form. Established institutions such as SRM Institute of Science and Technology and Madras Christian College contribute to a vibrant academic and cultural environment, while healthcare providers like Sri Ramachandra Medical Centre and Apollo Hospitals ensure reliability in everyday life. Beyond these anchors, newer elements such as cafés, retail spaces, and leisure hubs are gradually emerging. This evolving ecosystem offers something unique -



the opportunity to be part of a neighbourhood that is still shaping itself, where lifestyle is not pre-defined but continuously developing.

becoming more decentralised, bringing work, travel, and lifestyle closer together.

A Lifestyle Defined by Ease, Not Effort

Taken together, these shifts point to a broader transformation in how life is experienced along the ORR. It is a lifestyle defined by reduced friction, less time spent navigating the city, greater control over daily schedules, and a more seamless balance between work and personal life.

"The market saw moderate growth initially, followed by a sharp uptick in the last two to three years, driven by infrastructure investments and growing usage of the corridor. This trajectory appears sustainable," adds Dileep.

What emerges is not just a real estate opportunity, but a more intuitive way of living, where the city adapts to residents, rather than the other way around.

Where Chennai's Next Chapter Is Being Lived

As Chennai continues to expand, the Chennai Outer Ring Road is steadily transitioning from a connector into a defining lifestyle spine. It represents a shift towards a more balanced urban experience, one that prioritises accessibility, space, and everyday comfort. For residents, this translates into something both simple and significant: a city that feels easier to live in. In shaping this shift, the ORR is not just supporting Chennai's growth, it is quietly redefining how the city will be experienced in the years to come.

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I jostle my way through peak summer crowds to reach the small counter of the Famous Jigarthanda outlet at Kamarajar Street in Madurai. There are over a dozen outstretched hands along with mine, eager, and waiting. We see the golden-brown dessert being assembled in under five seconds: a chilled concoction is poured into tall glasses, then topped with scoops of caramel-coloured ice cream. This ice cream, the defining ingredient of jigarthanda, was first made in the kitchen of a one-roomed, 100 sq ft home in the nearby Mahalipatti neighbourhood, 70 years ago.

The Hindi word jigarthanda can be translated to ‘that which cools the heart’. The dessert, which consists of jelly-like bits of badam *pisin*, ice cream, basundi, and nannari syrup, is present in every other street in Madurai, and has now spread to other parts of the State and beyond. Famous Jigarthanda is said to be the name that gave the dessert its present form. The shop has 20

The iconic chilled dessert from Madurai, popular across the State and beyond, has its roots in a small home kitchen in the city

branches in Madurai, and 400 others spread across Tamil Nadu, Telangana, Karnataka and Puducherry through the franchise model.

The man who started it all, Sheik Meeran, came to Madurai from Arampannai village in Thoothukudi in search of a better life in the 1960s. He decided to try his hand selling ice cream inspired

by a few *kuchi* ice (ice lolly) sellers in Madurai. Meeran bought a few extra litres of milk from the local milkman one morning. “His wife Noor Hudhaya simmered the milk with sugar over a wood-fire,” says Mohammad Rabic, a cousin in the family.

Once it cooled, Meeran churned it in a hand-cranked ice cream machine that had an insulated outer

That which cools the heart Jigarthanda being assembled at the Kamarajar Street outlet in Madurai; Shahul Hameed (left) and Chintha Mathar in a photo taken in the 1990s. MOORTHY G AND SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT



compartment of ice mixed with salt. He then scooped the ice cream into a steel *thooku* and set out to sell it door-to-door. Meeran had four sons and two daughters and one of his sons usually accompanied him.

S Amanulla, the youngest, remembers walking with his father along the mud roads of erstwhile Madurai. Meeran was known as the ‘ice *bhai*’. “We would start from home at 10.30am, selling a serving for four or eight annas,” recalls Amanulla. Meeran would holler ‘ice! ice!’ as he walked with the steel container. “We carried small bowls fashioned out of palm leaves to serve the ice cream; some people also bought it in their own containers,” he adds. They were usually sold out by 3pm, after which they started preparations for the next day.

Meeran made ice cream in small

batches, enough to feed his family. “Our life revolved around ice cream,” Amanulla says.

Gradually, word spread on Meeran’s ice cream and he started getting orders for weddings and small events. He switched to a handcart and in the 1970s, operated on a cart from the same spot where their most popular shop stands today in Vilakuthoon.

It was by accident that Meeran discovered the combination for jigarthanda. “One evening, he had almost run out of ice cream,” recalls Rabic. “He had only a little left, and some nannari syrup, milk cream, and soaked badam *pisin* that he’d kept for toppings.”

Meeran, who didn’t want to send his customers empty-handed, threw in a little of everything and offered it in glasses. The result was a nutty, mildly-sweet dessert.

That evening, Madurai tasted its first jigarthanda. Customers came back the next evening, asking for the same thing. “He then perfected the combination over the next few weeks to arrive at the present form,” Rabic adds. It was not like the dessert became an overnight sensation. Meeran worked at it.

Famous Jigarthanda has five factories in the city, and most of the work is automated. But the mixing happens at the counter, seconds before the glass is handed to the customer.

Amanulla can never forget the taste of the ice cream his father made at their Mahalipatti home in the 1960s. “People would say it tasted like *amirtham* [the food of the gods],” says Rabic. It is that taste they aspire to, and they are actually very close.

A coastal soirée

Experience the flavours of South India’s coastline at A Refined Coastal Soirée, a culinary collaboration with the award-winning restaurant HOSA from Goa and Gurugram, led by Brand Chef Harish Rao. Known for his innovative approach to South Indian cuisine, Harish brings a contemporary interpretation of coastal cooking inspired by the culinary traditions of Goa, Mangaluru, Kerala and Chennai. “My idea is to showcase some of the popular dishes from HOSA. Coastal cuisine is not limited to seafood — we are focussing equally on vegetarian and non-vegetarian specialties,” he says.

The pop-up features curated vegetarian and non-vegetarian set menus that celebrate familiar flavours while introducing contemporary presentation. Reflecting the freshness of the summer season, the menu includes dishes such as nungu era curry, coconut milk rasam, shimeji mushroom varuval, buberGINE steak, pineapple curry, green grape pickle and curry leaf pesto fish.

The showcase reflects Harish’s signature style of reimagining heritage recipes through a modern dining experience in an elegant seaside setting.

@Sheraton Grand Chennai Resort & Spa, from May 8 to 10 for lunch and dinner. The vegetarian set menu is priced at ₹4,000 and the non-vegetarian set menu is at ₹4,500 per person. For reservations, call 7824092004.



Thinking caps on

At the Room Of Children’s Philosophies, independent educator Rhea Kuthoore will host a summer programme for children to explore philosophical questions through stories and games. For ages 11 to 14, on Saturdays and Sundays. Contact 8816933078 to register.



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At 104 years Ratni Bai Chordia is deeply engaged with the world around her. Whether it is playing *pallankuzhi* for hours or reading a Hindi newspaper daily, the centenarian from Mylapore follows a steady routine.

Long-time residents of Mylapore remember Ratna Mahal, the two-storied vintage building, on Bazaar Road and the family that lived there until 2006. The house belonged to S Manicklal Chordia, a Gandhian, social worker, and member of the Indian National Congress. While Manicklal passed away in 2010, his wife, Ratni Bai, moved to Mylapore to live with one of her sons.

“Amma,” as she is fondly called by her family of 149 members spread across India, remains central to their lives. Born in 1923, Ratni Bai’s family migrated to Bangalore during her early

Dice, pickles and memories

From hosting Congress leaders at home, to now playing pallankuzhi for hours; meet 104-year-old Ratni Bai Chordia of Mylapore

years. At 14, as a young bride, she moved to Madras. She delivered 16 children, of whom 13 survived.

Today, her five surviving children cherish her deeply. “One of the best ways to spend time with Amma is to play board games with her,” says her son, Chandraprakash Chordia.

“Raised in a strict environment, I had little time for recreation while managing a large household and raising 13 children. After my husband passed away, I finally found time for board games,” says Ratna Bai.

A favourite pastime for the centenarian is playing

chaupad (dice) or *pallankuzhi* (a traditional two-player board game from Tamil Nadu). Every day, she spends at least three hours playing, with unwavering focus and

Playing chaupad and pallankuzhi was, in a sense, liberating for me. Today, this is my way of connecting with people around me

RATNI BAI CHORDIA



Timeless spirit Surrounded by family memories and traditions, Ratni Bai Chordia reflects the enduring legacy of old Mylapore. VELANKANNI RAJ B

enthusiasm. Frail and wheel-chair bound, her spirited nature and love for simple joys keeps her cheerful.

“Playing chaupad and pallankuzhi was, in a sense, liberating for me. My sister-in-law (my husband’s sister) taught me these games. Today, this is my way of connecting with people around me and overcoming the grief of losing five of my children,” says Ratni Bai.

Ratna Mahal used to be a hub of activity. The house frequently hosted leaders from the Indian National Congress, with guests sometimes staying for weeks. The kitchen was always busy, with Ratni Bai preparing food for everyone. “When the 70th session of the Indian National Congress was held in Avadi in January 1955, Jawaharlal Nehru and many other national leaders came to Madras to participate. My

mother who cooked North Indian meals for these leaders, would pack four tiffin carriers and send them to Avadi,” recalls Mahendar Chordia, her sixth son.

K Kamaraj (former Chief Minister of Tami Nadu) and R Venkatraman (former President of India) were close friends of Manicklal, and were frequent visitors to Ratna Mahal spending hours discussing politics. “Diwali puja was a grand affair in our household, and my father would wait until Kamaraj came and only then perform the puja. This continued for over 15 years, until Kamaraj passed away,” Mahendar says.

Her granddaughter, Manasvi, describes her as an inspiration to her generation — someone who lived life without compromise.

“She was an independent woman, and her husband was a liberal person. She would wear traditional Rajasthani jewellery every day as long as my grandfather lived.”

“She never missed a Hindi film, and would go to Star Talkies in Thiruvallikeni, and continued going to theatres until five years ago. Now, at 104, Ratni Bai Chordia happily watches movies on OTT platforms at home,” says Manasvi.

“Grandmom is like a magnet. She embraces changing times and happily plays dice with my nine-year-old son,” says Manasvi, recalling Ratni Bai Chordia’s centenary celebration attended by 136 family members in 2023.

At 104, it is perhaps these simple routines — reading, pickling, playing, and remembering — that continue to define amma’s enduring spirit.

QUICK CROSSWORD #52
(Set by Doppelganger)

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9 Theatrical play (5)
10 Relating to a king (5)
11 Excessive concern with oneself (7)
12 Large streams (6)
14 Certainly (6)
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19 Country in Northeastern Africa (5)
22 Coach (5)
23 Collapse (7)
24 Meal (5)
25 Section (7)

Down

1 Subsequent to (5)
2 Bright (5)
3 Usual (7)
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7 Exhibited briefly (7)

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Solution No. 52

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Vijay in a still from *Sarkar*; a fan celebrating his victory in the recent elections. JOHAN SATHYADAS



CONTINUED FROM
» PAGE 1

Dhananjayan says *Kaththi* (2014) was Vijay’s most political film. “He brought up issues that plagued farmers. It signalled that Vijay is aligned with the people,” says the producer, who adds that signing *Sarkar* was yet another step in the political ladder through cinema, “Destiny guided him to pick the kind of stories that marked his entry into politics.”

Time to lead
Rewind to 2002, and you have *Thamizhan*, in which Vijay

A ticket to power

plays a lawyer whose goal is to spread awareness about the law to the common man. In this movie, he pulls up several public servants – including a bus conductor who denies small change to a senior citizen

and Corporation officials who neglect their official duties. Then there is *Thalaivaa*, the 2013 film that 29-year-old Mohamed Ashik, a fan, recalls with fondness. “Watching that film and its powerful scenes

gave me goosebumps,” says Ashik, about the film which had sequences showcasing Vijay glorifying the importance of unity and saving people stuck in riots.

Beyond the film’s content, *Thalaivaa* – which translates to ‘leader’ – is remembered for the challenges Vijay faced to get it released. Its tagline – ‘time to lead’ – reportedly irked the then Tamil Nadu Government led by Chief Minister Jayalalithaa, thus leading to a two-week delay in its release. “Back then, watching Vijay and the *Thalaiva* team undergo so many hurdles just to release their film gave it extra hype, and hence, watching it FDFS will remain special to me,” describes Ashik, who hails from Kandalurkottai in Pudukottai district. “Many friends of mine, who are regulars at Vijay FDFS fan celebrations, voted for Vijay, with some even urging the elders of the house to do the same,” adds Ashik, who is also the admin of multiple social media pages like @vijayfanstrends (500k followers) and ActorVijayUniverse (213K followers), besides TVK-related social media accounts.

The hitmaker
All this brings us to the beginning of 2026, when Vijay’s *Jana Nayagan* was set to hit screens. Said to be a heavy

The controversy surrounding the release of *Jana Nayagan* has brought about a wave of sympathy in Vijay’s favour. He also got a lot of support from within the film industry during that tough phase

RATHNA KUMAR
Writer-director

political film with emotional undertones, this movie – directed by H Vinoth – was supposed to be Vijay’s swansong before he turned to politics.

The film, originally slated for a festive release on January 9 ahead of Pongal, was postponed due to the delay in granting a censor certificate by the Central Board of Film Certification and a consequent legal battle. To complicate things, *Jana Nayagan* was leaked in High Definition on April 10 on piracy sites, with clips making their way to social media platforms.

This, however, created a massive emotional outpouring for Vijay.

“It obviously brought about a wave of sympathy in his favour,” says filmmaker Rathna Kumar, a self-confessed fan and the co-writer of hit Vijay films like *Master* and *Leo*. “In fact, we saw how much support he got from within the

industry during those tough times. They may not have tweeted about his political entry, but when they realised that this had affected the lives of so many workers – and that it wasn’t just about money but also emotions – they had to condemn it.”

The release of *Jana Nayagan*, whenever it happens, will now hold special meaning to Vijay’s fans – for, it no longer stars Vijay the superstar; Vijay the politician will take charge. Witnessing this drama unfold along with thousands of his fans will be Vijay’s father, SA Chandrasekar, who introduced the actor in 1992’s *Naalaya Theerpu* (which translates to ‘tomorrow’s judgement’).

“Voters did not see him as a *thalaivan* (leader). They saw him as *annan* (a brother),” said a beaming Chandrasekar after the election results.

In the next few weeks, Vijay has several crucial decisions to make. He will have to negotiate for seats, maybe pass a floor test and if all goes well – the newly-minted politician will have an entire State looking at him with a lot of hope. Unlike his idealistic films, problems might not get resolved within a few sequences or the runtime of a song, but would need a more measured and practical approach. Will his political phase be a blockbuster?

With inputs from
Bhuvanesh Chandar

Breaking the glass ceiling

Through ChampionWoman, the Global Adjustments Foundation is building resilience, and confidence



Stepping stones (Left) ChampionWomen initiative by Global Adjustments Foundation; (inset) director Mani Ratnam and Suhasini Maniratnam. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

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“Can we build a whole generation of calm, resilient, and powerful women leaders?” asks Ranjini Manian, founder chair, Global Adjustments Foundation.

This question has quietly shaped the last 10 years of her work. Through ChampionWoman, the foundation’s flagship initiative, Ranjini has focussed not on declarations of change, but on something more steady: equipping women to stay, grow, and lead within the systems they inhabit.

The idea took shape after two decades of working closely with multi-national companies through her relocation and cross-cultural firm, where a pattern became hard to ignore: women were entering the workforce in increasing numbers, but not staying long enough to rise. Careers stalled midway, often interrupted by life’s demands, workplace dynamics, or a quiet erosion of confidence.

ChampionWoman, she says, was her response to that gap, not as a programme of support alone, but as a framework to build what she describes as three essential traits: calmness, resilience, and the ability to own one’s power. “Calm, because life will throw

curveballs. Resilient, because you have to bounce back. And powerful, because you need to own your space,” she says.

This philosophy finds expression in the foundation’s workshops, which are designed to address the everyday realities women navigate at work. From mindful leadership sessions to modules on assertiveness and communication, the focus is on helping women stay the course and learning not just when to step up, but how to do so with clarity and control.

Central to this is what she calls “whole brain living”, a framework that encourages women to draw on different emotional and cognitive responses in the face of challenges. “There’s a wise voice, a taskmaster, a playful voice, and one that gives you a sense of adventure. When you learn to use all of them, you’re able to manage relationships and situations

much better,” says Ranjini.

The foundation’s Shakti Scholars programme takes this work a step further, focussing on young women from underserved backgrounds. More than a scholarship, it is designed as a leadership pipeline, combining financial support with training in communication, workplace readiness, and emerging skills. “We don’t just pick a girl, put her through college, and expect a degree to change her life. We make her career-intentional,” she says.

That approach has steadily widened the foundation’s reach, with scholars going on to work in companies such as Freshworks, Barclays, and Standard Chartered, often as the first women in their families to enter the professional workforce.

The programmes themselves have extended across sectors – from corporate offices and manufacturing floors to Government institutions, healthcare systems, and the armed forces, touching close to a million women over the past decade.

The next decade, she says, is about expanding both reach and depth through partnerships, funding, and a wider network of trained facilitators. “I’m not chasing numbers. I’m chasing impact that can be expanded by many other women doing the same work,” she says.



Bejewelled legacy (Clockwise from left) The new VBJ flagship store on Anna Salai, Chennai; designer pieces from the store; and brothers Amarendran Vummidi and Jithendra Vummidi. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT



Built to last

Nearly eight decades after crafting the sengol, the Vummidi family launches a 14,000 sq ft flagship showroom on Anna Salai

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There are objects that outlive the hands that shape them.

They carry memory, meaning, and power. The sengol, a ceremonial sceptre rooted in Tamil tradition once used to mark the transfer of power between rulers, is one such object.

In August 1947, as India stood on the cusp of independence, it was ceremonially presented to India’s first Prime Minister Jawaharlal Nehru by priests of the Thiruvaduthurai Adheenam, a centuries-old Saivite monastery, reviving a Chola-era ritual to symbolise the transfer of power. The sceptre was crafted in Madras by the family behind Vummidi Bangaru Jewellers (VBJ), embedding, within its form, a legacy of craftsmanship that would, for decades, remain largely unspeakable.

“In 2019, a Tamil publication wrote about my grandfather. I got curious and started to look around... In two years’ time, we found out where the sengol was. It was misrepresented as a golden walking stick of Nehru and placed in the Allahabad museum,” says Amarendran Vummidi, managing partner and fourth generation owner of VBJ. The rest as they say, is history.

Now installed beside the Speaker’s chair in India’s Parliament, the sengol has been restored to its symbolic place in the country’s political and cultural imagination.

Nearly eight decades later, that legacy finds a new expression on Anna Salai, where VBJ has opened its all-new flagship showroom, a 14,000 sq. ft. space adjoining its existing store. Spread across three floors, the store separates its offerings by category: gold and precious jewellery on the ground level, diamonds and platinum on the first, and an exclusive, appointment-led space on the second.

The company operates multiple manufacturing units across Chennai, Mumbai and Bengaluru, supported by an in-house design team with young graduates from institutes such as NIFT and NID, who work on developing original collections. “The first floor has a section dedicated to designer jewellery, starting from ₹50,000 up to ₹70 lakh,” says Amarendran, adding that there is also a design counter where customers can customise jewellery based on their likes.

The new store is part of a wider expansion plan for the brand, which is looking to grow its presence across Tamil Nadu and Telangana, with upcoming stores in cities such as Coimbatore, Tiruchirappalli and



The sengol (now installed beside the Speaker’s chair in the Parliament) was misrepresented as a golden walking stick of Nehru and placed in the Allahabad museum

AMARENDRAN VUMMIDI
Managing Partner

Hyderabad. The company is also scaling its international operations, building on its presence in Texas with plans to expand into California, targeting the Indian diaspora.

The future is already beginning to take shape within the family. Diyya Vummidi, daughter of managing partner Jithendra Vummidi and a Gemology graduate of the Gemological Institute of America, says, “What my grandfather has always held strongly are values: trust, integrity, innovation, and really good quality work, and always giving customers exactly what we say we are giving. He taught us to take our time, do it slowly, do it right, and everything else will fall into place,” she says.

Alongside her sister and two cousins, she is part of a cohort of four women set to enter the business, a first for the family. “We are four women and that’s something that has not happened in our family yet. I’m looking forward to having them beside me,” says the 31-year-old.



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29 and counting

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“Who are you?” — this is the question a radio jockey poses to some 29-year-old men. They respond by stating their names. “No, that’s your name. Who are you?” she repeats. They now explain that they are chartered accountants, software engineers, and so on. “But that’s your profession. Who are you?” One man responds that he is human, to which she says so is everyone else. “Who are you?” She then asks a young man, seemingly lost in thought, and he says: “I don’t know.” This is how writer-director Rathna Kumar teases the theme of his upcoming film, 29, in a promo. “It is primarily a romance drama,” says Rathna. “But there are things beyond that — like self-discovery — which would connect with even those who aren’t that keen about love and relationships. It will be a film that will give you a lot of hope.” Rathna first wrote down the seed of this idea as a Facebook

post long ago. “Many praised it. One friend even suggested I delete it, saying it had the potential to become a film. I kept that idea aside.” He then imbued it with the identity crisis he was facing on the personal front, issues he faced when he was a 29-year-old. “It’s a film set in the early 2010s, and follows the story of a 29-year-old. It has 10 segments to it.” This age bracket, when middle-life crisis begins to set in, has its own set of challenges, adds Rathna, who is now 40. Rathna has had a long working relationship with the films’ producers, Karthik Subbaraj and Lokesh Kanagaraj — he directed his debut *Meyaadha Maan* for Karthik and co-wrote the scripts of Lokesh’s *Master*, *Vikram* and *Leo*. Lokesh and Karthik backing the film — and Sean Roldan’s music, which he says is the film’s backbone — have particularly helped the film since it doesn’t have known faces, says Rathna. 29 stars Vidhu (who played the antagonist opposite Suriya in *Retro*) and Preethi Asrani (of *Ayothi* fame). The director agrees that promoting a film with newcomers is challenging.

Director Rathna Kumar speaks about his film 29 and the pros and cons of making a love story with newcomers

“If you go for a big star, you might have to give in to their wishes regarding certain aspects. But you can be a bit relaxed during the release. In our case, we can make the film entirely the way we wish to, but we might have to struggle to position the film.” On the flipside, what works in favour of 29 is that these actors do not come with a certain image, and thus, appear as their characters. Rathna understands the importance of this. “When I did *Aadai*, Amala Paul had a certain image, and so the film

attracted expectations. When I did *Gulu Gulu* with Santhanam sir, people came in expecting him to throw one-liners and jokes regularly, when in fact, he had only a few dialogues in the film. That again ended up affecting the film.” Further, he also seems to have taken it as a challenge to make the film within the limited budget that a fresh cast allows for. Rathna says there are three important requisites for a love story to work: good performers, confident producers who trust you, and a catchy music album. “Beyond all that, the script should be different from films that have been made before. Moreover, an edgy off-beat film could hold the audience due to its unique treatment; 29 too will need good treatment, but you need to tick all the boxes to make a love story work. Everything should work, or else, people might say ‘they are talking a lot’ or ‘they are always lovey-dovey.’ We need to position the film right, and only then will we get right audience and the right reviews.”



29 releases in theatres on May 8

Aura of the Big Ms

Director Mahesh Narayanan talks about working with Mammootty and Mohanlal in *Patriot*



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A star-studded ensemble cast with names like Kunchacko Boban, Fahadh Faasil, Nayanthara, Darshana Rajendran, Revathi and Rajiv Menon. A highly decorated crew coming together for one of the expensive movies in Malayalam. Mahesh Narayanan’s *Patriot* had many things going for it, but the highlight of the film is the coming together of Malayalam cinema’s two superstars, Mammootty and Mohanlal, after 18 years. Mahesh Narayanan opens up on casting the two stars and watching them perform:



Watching them perform “We started the shoot with Lal sir, and Mammookka joined two days later. Their first shot was the flashback scene where Mammookka helps Lal sir fix his artificial limb. During the shoot, I didn’t think it was special. It was only when my team mentioned it that I realised that I have Mammootty and Mohanlal in the same frame in my movie. It was nice to watch the ease with which they went about the shot. Many have asked whether I got a high watching them together. Not really. But their performance gave me a high. You can’t deny that there is an aura about them as they carry a scene. They are actors who are submissive to the filmmaker since they know the purpose of the movie. Also, I didn’t have to make compromises as a filmmaker because of their star power. Nobody asked me to adapt the narrative for them. In fact, Lal sir specifically told me nothing extra for him! He understood the emotion the character entails.”

Bringing the stars together “People are saying I became part of history by casting them together. That is a misunderstanding. This is my film and they came to act in my movie. It is not like I made a film because they wanted me to make one. They came on board because they have watched my movies. I finalise an actor only when the screenplay is ready; same with *Patriot*. I approached Mammookka because I felt he was apt for the role. Lal sir was his suggestion as Col Rahim. Lal sir said the role resonated with him and he was hardly bothered about what happened to the character at the end. I believe the twist irked many of his fans. Lal sir said he loved the role since he had not done something like this. He knew

Patriot is running in theatres

Bringing the beat home

Wheeza Collective wants Chennai to party. Its May 16 event promises pomp, themes, and a space to meet new faces

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Barring two Chennai pubs that somehow metamorphose into clubs on Friday nights, there are hardly any dedicated spaces to go out dancing in the city. “In those spaces too, playlists remain the same,” says Vardhan Athreya. Tired of the monotonous clubbing scene that offers little beyond familiar faces and generic music, Wheeza Collective, co-founded by Vardhan and Kasim Marwaan, embarked on a mission in 2024 to inject fresh energy and introduce a truly distinct sound into the city. Their journey began with a simple desire: to create a space where Chennaites could truly dance, connect, and experience a global tapestry of music, including their rich Tamil heritage. The genesis of this movement traces back to a late-night call between friends. Vardhan, a DJ who had experienced London’s underground music scene, had recently returned to Chennai after college in 2024. Kasim was in Canada, listening to mixes of Tamil songs by a diasporic community from across the globe, taking pride in the music whose genesis lay in the city. They realised Chennai was missing a crucial element: curated nights and a variety of genres. “If it’s happening in Canada and the



Make a move Wheeza Collective has hosted 11 events till date -- all with the intention of ensuring a party pops. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

UK and it’s getting more popular there, Chennai should also be the place where we should be doing these,” Kasim says. Their solution: to slowly experiment with different genres, and bring the party here. Their first event was a private, invite-only house party for 80 people in a rented villa on the ECR in December 2024, says Vardhan. They meticulously curated the experience, transforming the villa into a club-like atmosphere with cameras and bouncers, even incorporating a “white party” theme. This intimate setting allowed them to experiment with their unique musical blend, which included English, Tamil, and Hindi music, a stark contrast to the predominantly English playlists found in most Chennai clubs. The success of their house party propelled them to expand. They consciously avoided traditional clubs to maintain their unique identity. “If everyone goes to the same club, how am I gonna stand out?” Vardhan asked. Instead, they sought out newer,

odd venues, transforming unexpected spaces like Asvah, an Italian restaurant on the beach, into a popping club for a night. Their other themed events, such as a Moroccan rooftop sounder at Koox in September 2025, proved to be hits too. These events were not just about the music; they were immersive experiences with elaborate decor, like converting a place into a jungle for a jungle-themed night. This worked in their favour. The team including Vedanth Raja, Nila Srinivas, and Tamaara Kurian, ended up realising that people loved dressing up, adhering to themes, and meeting new, young inhabitants of the city. The movement is also attracting talented DJs from outside Chennai, like Nida from Delhi, who will be performing on May 16, playing dance music and House. They prioritise DJs who align with their vision of pushing new sounds rather than just big names. “We are more focussed on the brand being the crowd puller. Not the specific DJ,” Vardhan explains. Vardhan, Kasim and the team are intent on redefining Chennai’s cultural landscape. How they want to do it: one beat at a time.

Wheeza Collective’s journey began with the desire to create a space where Chennaites could truly dance, connect, and experience a global tapestry of music

For details about upcoming events, follow @wheeza_collective on Instagram.



Singeetham Srinivasa Rao’s next titled *Sing Geetham*

Legendary filmmaker Singeetham Srinivasa Rao had recently announced his return to filmmaking at the age of 94. The veteran director’s movie is being produced by Nag Ashwin under the prestigious banners Vyjayanthi Movies and Swapna Cinema. Now, the makers have announced the movie’s title and release date. The upcoming movie is called *Sing Geetham*. Billed as “India’s first musical fantasy,” the film is set to hit the theatres on June 11, 2026. The release date was announced with a teaser. The official logline of the movie reads, “Set against the backdrop of a mysterious and isolated village, *Sing Geetham* follows a young man, Prathap, whose pursuit of opportunity leads him into a world where nothing is as it seems. As he becomes entangled in forces larger than himself, he is drawn into a conflict between progress and preservation — one that challenges his choices, beliefs, and sense of purpose.” The film stars Ayaan, Ahilya Bamroo, and Shalini Kondepudi. Ankur C is the cinematographer while Devi Sri Prasad has composed the music. Aravind Mulle has handled the production. Rao has co-written in the movie with Gautami Challagulla, Shashank, Sreekar, Nanda Kishore Emani and Rahul V Rajeshwar. Rao is known for many iconic films, like the silent film *Pushpak* and the visionary sci-fi movie *Aditya 369*. His collaborations with Kamal Haasan — including *Vichitra Sahodharlu* and *Michael Madana Kama Rajan* — were hit projects.

